I Wanna be a Cowboy

By Jon Tuttle

INTRODUCTION

WALTON: *Ya hear all these kids sayin' "I wanna be an astronaut..*
NELLA: *or a rock star*
WALTON: *or a lawyer*
NELLA: *or a doctor"*
WALTON: *not me.*
BOTH: *"I Wanna be a Cowboy"*
NELLA: *By Jon Tuttle*

(NELLA and WALTON occupy seats next to each other. She has the aisle seat: He stares wistfully out the window next to his seat and jingles quarters in his beefy palm. She is staring at him - or with him, out the window, wondering at his deep, blue mood - when the bus suddenly runs over something in the road. He doesn't move or break his stare, but after a moment, he breaks the silence)

WALTON: ... 'Dilla.

NELLA: ... Escuse me?

WALTON: 'Dilla.

NELLA: ' Dilla?

WALTON: 'Dilla, Ya hit 'em, they explode. Squirt out both ends like a burrita.

NELLA: ... Arma ...dilla?

WALTON: *(Still looking out his window)* Stupidest critters in Texas. Sit on the road like a idiot an' watch ya comin'. Then the highway department comes along'n paint yella lines right over their stupid backs. *(At the indignity of it)* Huh. Huh. *(NELLA contemplates the image, and he yanks off a bite of jerky, his head snapping back. Not wanting to lose the conversational momentum, she loads up a sentence and misfires.)*

NELLA: ... To where are you goin' to?

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WALTON: ... Dallas.

NELLA: ... We are as yet a considerable long distance to go to Dallas ... You cannot see Dallas at this time from where we are ... at.

WALTON: *(Turning to her)* I *know* that. Ya think I'm *stupid?* Ya think I'm some sorta *idiot?* - Shee! *(He yanks off another bite and looks back out his window. Pause. Nella resists, but then bursts into tears. She sputters, like she s trying to swear at herself.)*

NELLA: Hep! Kuh! Fut!

WALTON: *(Turning again, dumfounded)* ... What?

NELLA: Shup! Purt!

WALTON: What?

NELLA: What am I sayin'? I never know! Kufl

WALTON: Ya got some snot on yer chin.

NELLA: *(Quickly wiping it)* I'm sorry! I'm sorry what I implied! I think it all through! I try to be soooo - *(She pants hard, like some Lamaze breathing drill, trying to pull herself together. He doesn't know what to do.)*

WALTON: ... Want some jerky?

NELLA: *(Composing herself)* No, no thank you. I'm sorry. I'm terrible sorry.

WALTON: 'S OK. Ya got some more on yer cheek.

NELLA: Thank you. I'm sorry. *(She wipes her cheek, and he turns back to his window. She dries up a bit and tries again, tentatively.)* What are... I mean, for what are you looking... for?

WALTON: .., I'm scared.

NELLA: ... Of what are you scared of? *(But Walton cannot articulate it. He just shakes his head, stares, jingles and chews. Nella presses on. Indicating his shirt)* Are you a student at the Texas University of A&M?

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WALTON: Pff. Hell no. Not no more.

NELLA: I am on my way to be a freshman at the Texas Christian University. That's in Fort Worth. That's near Dallas.

WALTON: *(Sharply)* I know where Fort Worth is. *(Her lip quivers, but she fights it, and hangs in.)*

NELLA: I am from Clancy, Arkansas. And you?

WALTON: *(Out the window: the sum total of all his hopes)...* I wanna be a Cowboy.

NELLA: A cowboy. How very fascinatin'.

WALTON: *(To himself, mostly)* I'm *gonna* be a Cowboy, too. I am.

NELLA: Like Gene Autry?

WALTON: Like Walt Garrison.

NELLA: I do not believe as I with him am familiar. I don't know him.

WALTON: *(Turning to her now)* He's my hero. Ever since third grade with Miss Slocum. Got his poster up over my bed. Greatest Cowboy what ever lived. We got the same name almost, too. I'm Walton Dwight Pritchard. He's Walt Garrison. *(He yanks off another bite.)*

NELLA: How very fascinatin'. Does he sing?

WALTON: *(Baffled)...* I dunno.

NELLA: Do you have your own horse?

WALTON: ... Uh-uh.

NELLA: Oh, well, they'll prolly let you borrow one.

WALTON: In high school I won a trophy.

NELLA: A trophy. How very fascinatin'. My high school, which is in Clancy, they awarded me a scholarship to go to any good Christian school to which I wanted to go to, in so far as much as it was within a reasonable radius and had academic credentials. *(WALTON yanks off a bite.)*

WALTON: How come ya talk like that? That the way they talk in Arkansas?

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NELLA: *(Wells up.)* Hep! I'm sorrow! *(She starts crying again. Walton is confused again. He looks at his jerky, contemplates offering it again, looks up at her, down at it, back and forth, while she tries to regulate her breathing.)* My mamma, she says I got to go to a big school like Texas Christian is, so I can git my social graces on account'a I never know what I'm sayin'. However, I don't wanna go away to college. I just wanna stay at home.

WALTON: Yeah, well, college *sucks.*

NELLA: When I was a little girl? I wanted to be a cowgirl. On Career Day? At Hazelwood Elementary? I stood up and I said I want to be a cowgirl. But Joey Ray Draper, he said I already was, and then he mooed. By which he meant I was *fat.*

WALTON: Grade school sucks too.

NELLA: I wanted to wear one a them little cowgirl hats and vests with fringes and all and boots and be like Shirley Jones.

WALTON: Who's she?

NELLA: She was a cowgirl. You know, from "Oklahoma!"? She had pretty blond hair and she wasn't skinny but she-

WALTON: Oh yeah! She was in the poster what they done!

NELLA: I don't know 'bout no poster. That was a long time ago.

WALTON: That's her! Big Ol' blonde right up front. I didn't know she was from Oklahoma, is all. Them cowgirls, my Lord, they sure are a sight, huh?

NELLA: I was too fat, though.

WALTON: And you *know* them cowboys, they're gettin' some a that. Be fine by me. That's a laugh, huh! *(He snorts.)* Them cowgirls, that'd be a joke. They wouldn't even pay me the time a day. Even if I was a cowboy. Even if I was the greatest cowboy since Walt Garrison.

NELLA: How come?

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WALTON: 'Cause I'm stupid. *(He yanks off a bite, matter a/fact-like.)*

NELLA: Y'are?

WALTON: I'm a idiot. Been that way all my life. Least as far as I can remember. Which ain't very.

NELLA: I was fat once.

WALTON: Ask my daddy. He says I'm stupid to think I'm gonna be a cowboy. He says I should stay in Plano an' be a roughnecker like him on the oil field. He even, look here, he even give me these here quarters so's I can call him when I need a ride back home cause I'm too stupid to be a cowboy.

NELLA: You don't seem stupid to me.

WALTON: I don't?

NELLA: Nope. All the kids at Clancy High School? They were stupid. All the kids at Chester A. Arthur Middle School, they were stupid too, and the kids at Hazelwood Elementary? They were really stupid. You ain't stupid compared to alla them.

WALTON: Eh. I can't open my mouth without stickin' my butt in.

NELLA: Well... cowboys don't talk much, do they?

WALTON: That's true, huh.

NELLA: They're famous for their stoic - stois - they don't talk much.

WALTON: All my life, it's all I ever dreamed of. 'Specially Sunday afternoons, when they were on TV.

NELLA: Uh-huh, I watched 'em.

WALTON: Monday nights, too, when they were on. Cowboys were my heroes.

NELLA: Mine too, uh-huh.

WALTON: Really?

NELLA: Cowboys are most people's heroes, I always thought.

WALTON: Eh. Nobody ain't got no respect for 'em no more. Not like in the olden days.

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NELLA: Oh, I think they got a pretty firm place in our sociology.

WALTON: Ya think so?

NELLA: Uh-huh. Look at what all the cowboys stand for. Bravery. Integrity. Hard work.

WALTON: America.

NELLA: America. Freedom.

WALTON: They're against drugs, too.

NELLA: And you can't blame them for what happened to the Indians.

WALTON: Ya mean the Redskins?

NELLA: Uh-huh. The cowboys, they didn't represent the umperialism inherent in manyfest destiny. Quite the opposite, I'd say. Wouldn't you say?

WALTON: Yeah, but I hate the Redskins. What the Cowboys need now is to whomp the hell outa them again, at least one a year, like on Thanksgivin', just like the olden days. Wouldn't you say - what you say your name was?

NELLA: Nella. Nella Overholt.

WALTON: I mean, lookit where they are. Broncos run right over 'em now. How often that used ta happen?

NELLA: I didn't know it was that bad.

WALTON: It's pitiful. If they ain't careful, they're gonna wind up like ...the *Falcons.*

NELLA: You mean endangered?

WALTON: Exactly. Or Buffalo. Who gives a damn, I mean, who *really* gives a damn 'bout *Buffalo* any more?

NELLA: I thought they were extinct.

WALTON: They were, fer awhile. Bears, who can say with them. But the Dolphins? Lookit the Dolphins.

NELLA: Getting slaughtered by the thousands.

WALTON: Exactly!

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NELLA: Or the California condors.

WALTON: ... I ain't never heard a them.

NELLA: That proves my point.

WALTON: Exactly! And that's how the Cowboys are headed! I can't let that happen. No red-blooded, born and bred son a Texas can! I could help 'em get back to where they was, I swear I could! If I could be a Cowboy... God! Wouldn't people look up to me! Everybody in Plano! Everybody at A&M! Me! Walton Dwight Pritchard! *Cowboy! (The verv notion has pulled him to his feet. He takes his hat off and places it solemnly over his heart. NELLA is getting aroused.)*

NELLA: *(Heating up)* Oh, I would! I would!

WALTON: Would ya? Would ya really?

NELLA: I swear to God I would! Specially when you were on your horse!

WALTON: *(Baffled again)* But ... I ain't *got* no horse.

NELLA: You gotta believe in yourself, Walter!

WALTON: *(Shaking his head sadly)* Eh. It ain't so easy, believin' in yourself, when ... when ...

NELLA: When what?

WALTON: *(Earnest)* Nellie, yer a smart person, I can tell that. Ya know what yer talkin' 'bout. So I need to ask ya a question here. It's kinda personal though, an' I ain't ever asked it to no girl before. So I need ya to answer straight-forward.

NELLA: *(Hoping)* OK.

WALTON: *(Experimentally)* Nellie. Do ya think ...

NELLA: ...Yes?

WALTON: Do ya think... see, the thing is ...

NELLA: Yes? Yes?

WALTON: The thing is ... I got a *trophy, see.* An' I'm *strong.* Once, when I was at A&M, I

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hit a Texas Longhorn. Big sucker, open field, dead run. Broke *two* a his ribs. My Christ, the sound he made when he hit the ground! An' I stood up and waved my fist in the air ... *Yeeeow!* And I spit on him.

NELLA: *(Totally turned on; overpowered)* You broke ... the ribs ...of a *longhorn?*

WALTON: Uh-huh. How's that? Ya think I could be a Cowboy?

NELLA: Sweet Jesus, yes! Yes, I do!

WALTON: Yee-hoo! I knew I could! Daddy said I couldn't! Everybody said I couldn't! But I got somethin' in me, see, what says I can. I got *desire.* Ya gotta have desire, Nellie!

NELLA: *(She's SO got it.)* Oh, I *know!* I *know!*

WALTON: If ya got desire, Nellie

NELLA: I *know!*

WALTON: Ya can survive bein' stupid. Is what I say. But at A&M, they didn't see it that way. They - eh.

NELLA: What? They *what?!*

WALTON: Listen to me. You don't want to sit here and listen to me ramblin' on like a idiot.

NELLA: Yes, I do! This is the most intelligent conversation I've had since I don't know when!

WALTON: Me neither! At A&M, they kicked me out fer bein' stupid. They didn't say exacly that, but I knew it's what they meant. It's what everybody says. My daddy, he says Plano is the place fer a man like me, cause it's only Plano, and everybody's stupid. But I got desire! It burns in me like battery acid! I wanna be a Cowboy! But there's only one thing, one thing what I'm ascared of

NELLA: *(Holding his hand tightly)* What's that, Walter? You can tell me!

WALTON: *(The horror, the horror)* ... I'm ... stupid.

NELLA: Oh, Walter!

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WALTON: A thousand Texans can't be wrong! It burns in me day in and night out! An' the girls? They - pff. Pffff. They never even pay me the time a day. Not like you are here.

NELLA: *(Some spite here)* Most girls are *petty* and *mean* and *self centered* and *vain* and *superficial* and *ignorant* and *mean* and they only care about *one thing.*

WALTON: *Basketball.*

NELLA: Exactly. I hate basketball.

WALTON: Basketball *sucks.*

NELLA: I hated school altogether.

WALTON: Me too. Sucked. If I hear that word *stupid* one more time

NELLA: I was fat. All through high school.

WALTON: *(Diplomatically)...* No.

NELLA: I've lost seven pounds over the summer. Of course, there's still room for improvement.

WALTON: You ain't too fat.

NELLA: Well, no, not no more. Not *as* fat.

WALTON: You ain't fat at all.

NELLA: Well, I'm

WALTON: No, I've seen fat. Fat's bigger'n what you got there. Fat's all puffy and white an' you can draw yer name in it with yer finger. You ain't fat. .

NELLA: At my high school reunion I'm going to lose forty-eight pounds. I already lost seven.

WALTON: When's that?

NELLA: Ten years. I'll be skinny as a post. And when they ask me who I am, I'll say

WALTON: Say, I'm Shelley Jones. Cowgirl!

NELLA: Maybe so!

WALTON: An when they ask ya to dance, you can laugh in their stupid, ugly faces.

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NELLA: Well, I don't know if

WALTON: It'll make 'em feel stupid. I know.

NELLA: *(Protests too much.)* Well, maybe some of them. Like those idiots who strutted down the hall with their rippling biceps and big shoulders and washboard stomachs and granite thighs and hairy chests and letter jackets and never saw *anybody* but the *cheerleaders.* God, I hated them.

WALTON: Cheerleaders are *sluts.*

NELLA: I mean the basketball players and baseball players and football players and tennis players and wrestlers and golfers and

WALTON: Ya hated ... football players?

NELLA: Are you kidding? They're the worst! I hated them with a *passion.* I hated them with a burning, smoldering *passion!* If I had a nickel for every second I spent *hating* them

WALTON: How come ... ya hated ... football players?

NELLA: *(Isn't it obvious?)* ... Because ... football players are stupid! They're idiots. I never met a football player who wasn't as stupid as he could be. Wouldn't you say? *(Pause)*

WALTON: ... Yeah. I guess so. *(Pause, WALTON looks out his window and begins to jingle his change again. Then he turns back to NELLA as if to say something, something hard, but sees her there, looking at him expectantly, hopefully* So *he puts his hat back on and stares out his window. The bus hits something They jostle a bit, and she squeaks again, softly)*

NELLA: *(Happily, confidently)* ... 'Dilla. *(She sits smiling at the back of his head.)*

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